

The TMU Graduate Research-A-Thon

Incu Plex Sansdisciplinary Research
through Community & Competition

A proposal to transform the graduate experience: Not just generating ideas quickly, but producing better ideas—disciplined by scrutiny, supported by community, and designed for funding.

Executive Summary

The Problem

Inter Tight Semi-Bold



Graduate training is isolated, labs are siloed, and students lack protected time for interdisciplinary risk-taking.

The Solution

Inter Tight Semi-Bold



A 2-week, fully online, accessibility-first build sprint for all STEM graduate students.

- Virtual Hub (Discord/Zoom) 
- Humane Pacing (2 Weeks)
- Inclusive Design

The Output

Inter Tight Semi-Bold



Teams do not write code. They produce a concise, fundable research proposal (MVP).

The Ask

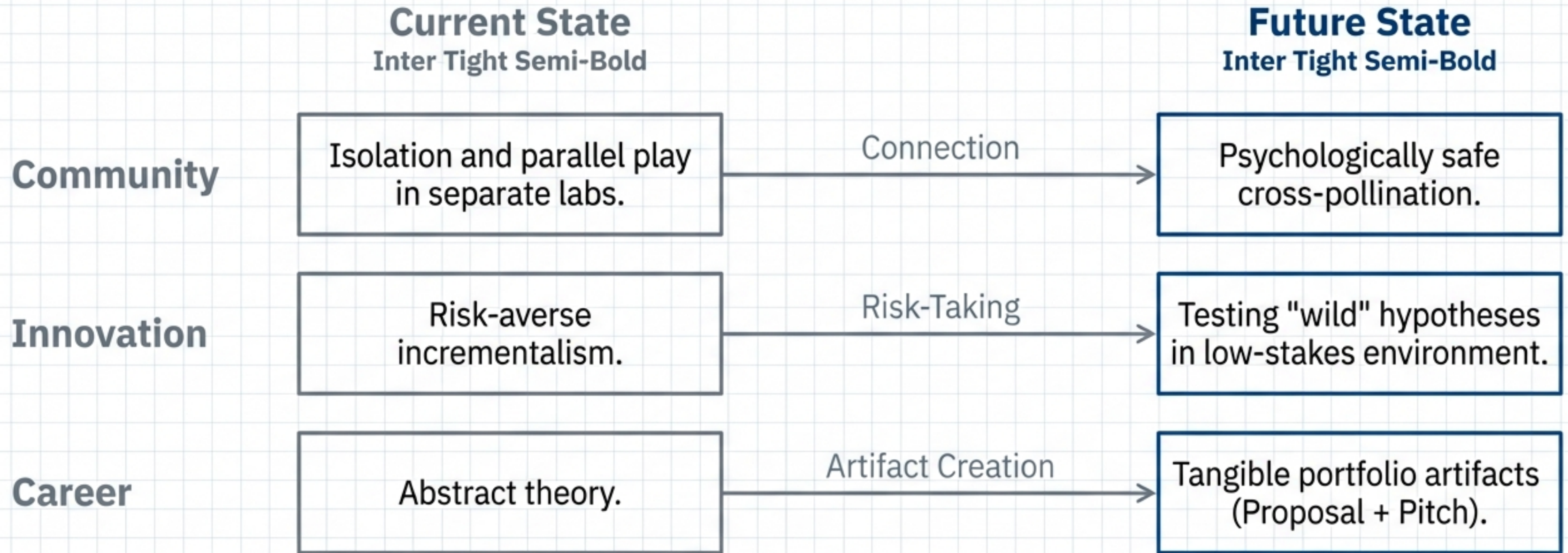
Inter Tight Semi-Bold



Approval of the concept and selection of a funding tier.

- Cash Grants
- Career Catalyst
- Grant Acceleration

The Strategic Gap: Why Do This?



Insight: Current mixers build social bonds but no output. Current **hackathons** build **code but ignore theory**. The Research-A-Thon fills this void.

Optimizing the Hackathon for Research

	Traditional Hackathon	The Research-A-Thon
Time	24-Hour Sprint (Burnout risk, excludes caregivers)	2-Week Timeline (Thoughtful pacing, accessible to all)
Output	Flashy Demos (Bias toward coding skills)	Mini-Proposals (Field-neutral: Gap, Question, Methods, Impact)
Goal	Does it run?	Is it rigorous and fundable ?

Accessibility Note:

The 2-week timeline allows “hardcore speedrunners” and “thoughtful architects” to participate equally.

Core Objectives & Goals



Community & Culture

Breaking down silos.
Creating a '**psychologically safe**' forum to articulate unconventional hypotheses.

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Ideation

Structured cross-pollination.
Intentional team formation to surface **high-leverage questions** in the niches between fields.

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Quality & Rigour

'Fail fast' feedback loops.
Participants write to a discipline-neutral template and receive rapid peer/mentor feedback.

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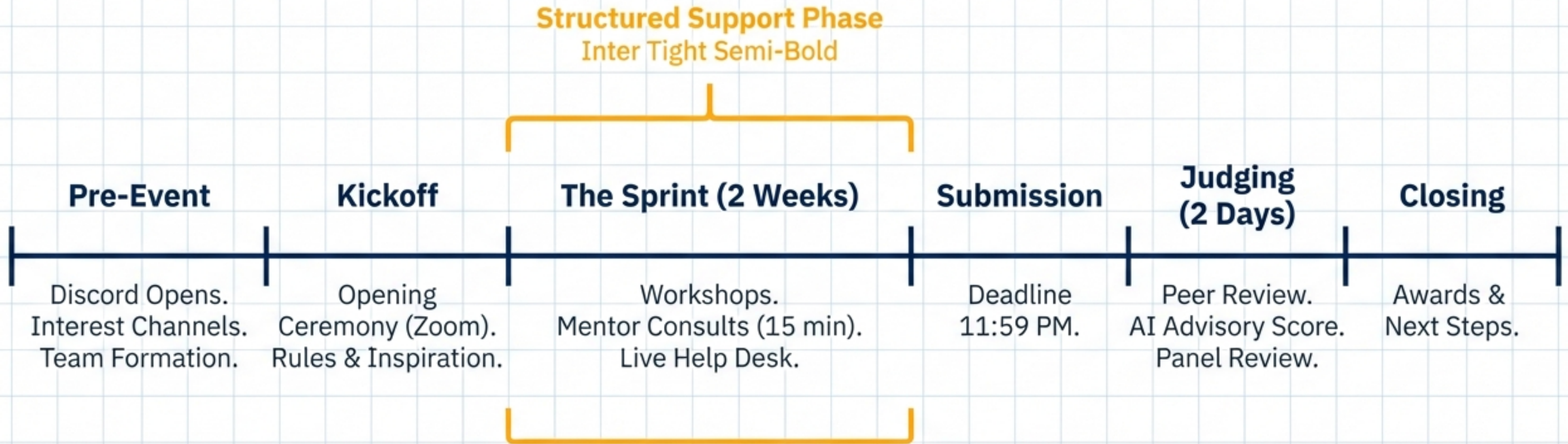


Career Readiness

Producing artifacts. A ≤ 3 -page proposal and a 3-minute pitch that map directly to **scholarship applications**.

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The Event Lifecycle



The Technical Stack & Accessibility

The Virtual Venue



Accessibility First

Low-Bandwidth Mode

Explicit norms for camera-off participation, dial-in audio, PDF slide backups.

Asynchronous Friendly

Recordings posted immediately for time-zone inclusion.

Humane Hours

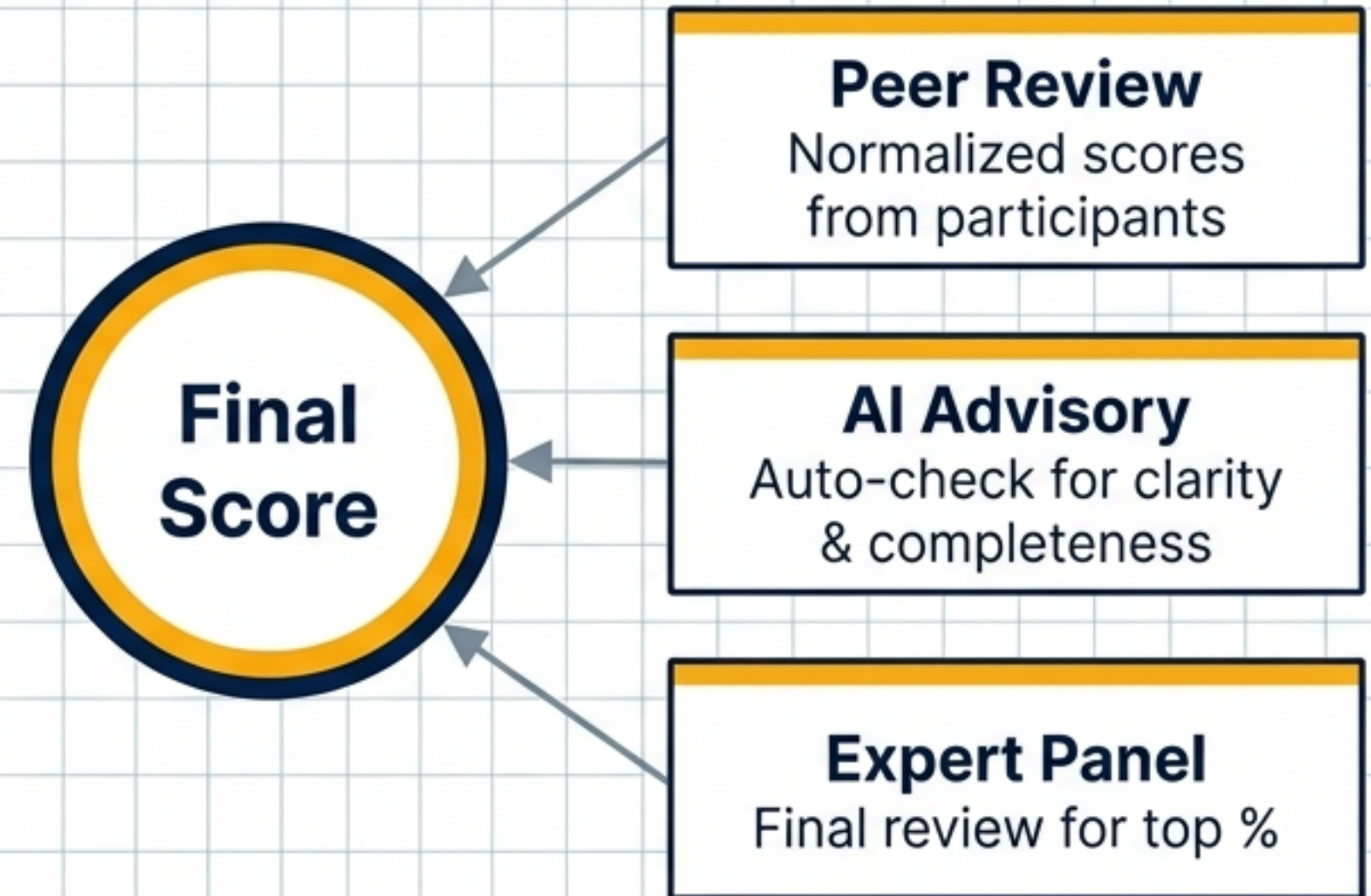
No all-nighters. Explicit scheduled breaks.

Deliverables & Innovation

The MVP Proposal

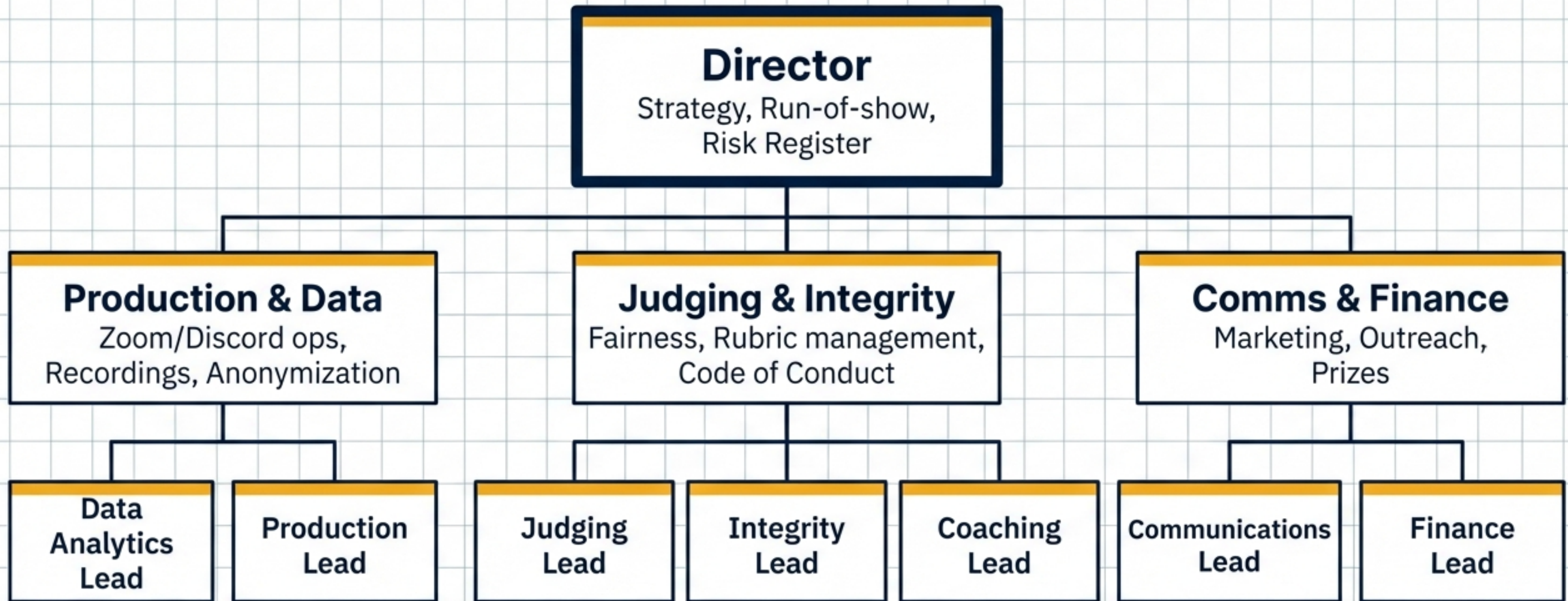


Triangulated Judging Process



AI Philosophy: Transparency over prohibition. Tools support brainstorming without supplanting scientific judgment.
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Leadership & Governance

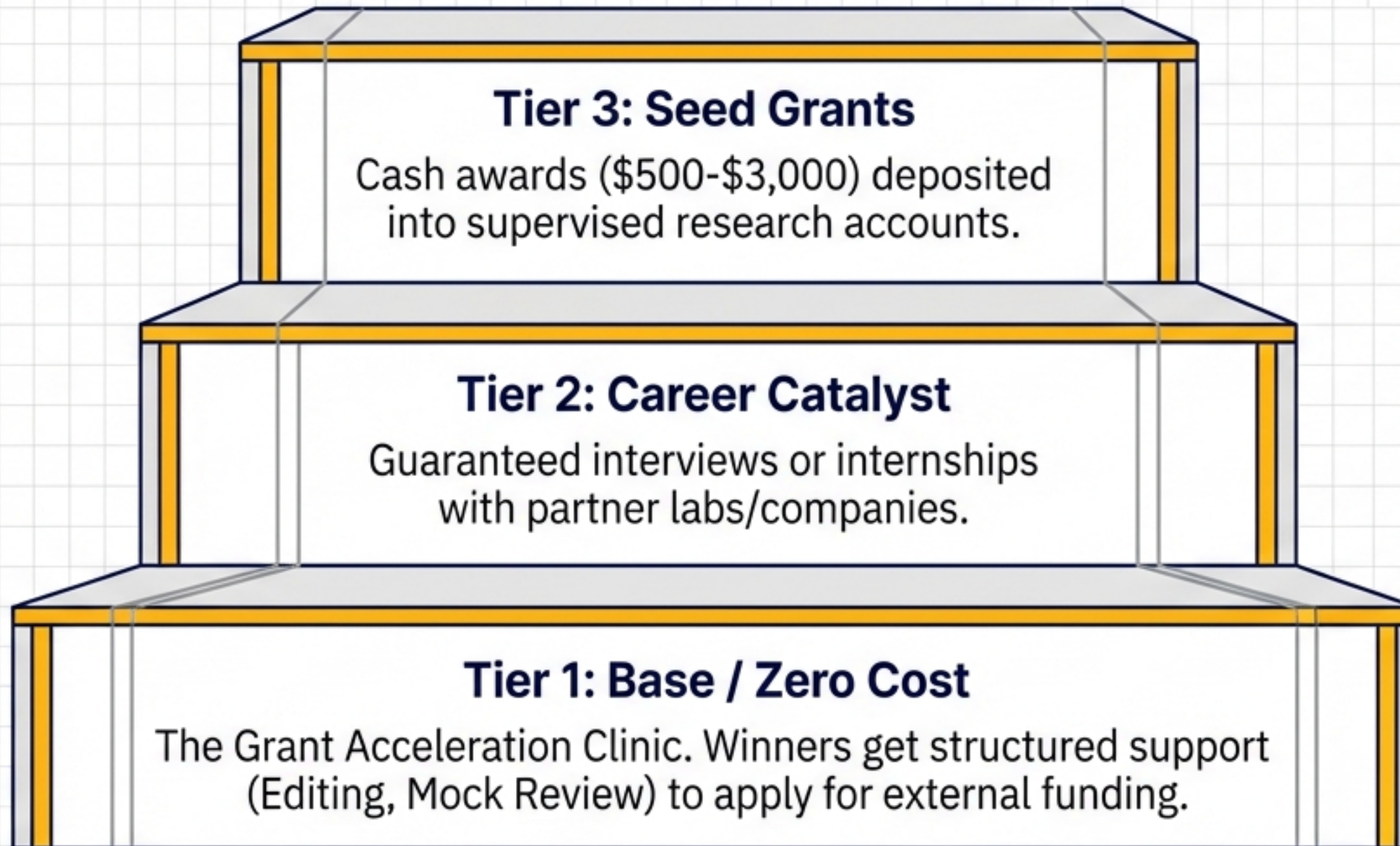


Roles mirror Student Union positions for scalability and recruitment.

Risk Mitigation & Safety

Risk Category	Specific Concern	Mitigation Strategy
Technology	Platform Failure	Backup Google Meet links; Discord voice failover; Low-bandwidth mode
Fairness	Bias & Subjectivity	Anonymized PDFs; Double-blind peer review; Normalized z-scores
Integrity	AI Misuse/Plagiarism	Mandatory disclosure statement; Human judgment on citations; Novelty focus
Conduct	Toxic Behavior	Strict Code of Conduct; Role-gated channels; Integrity Lead oversight
IP	Idea Theft	Teams retain IP. Option to remove cross-team peer review if sensitive.

The Incentives Model

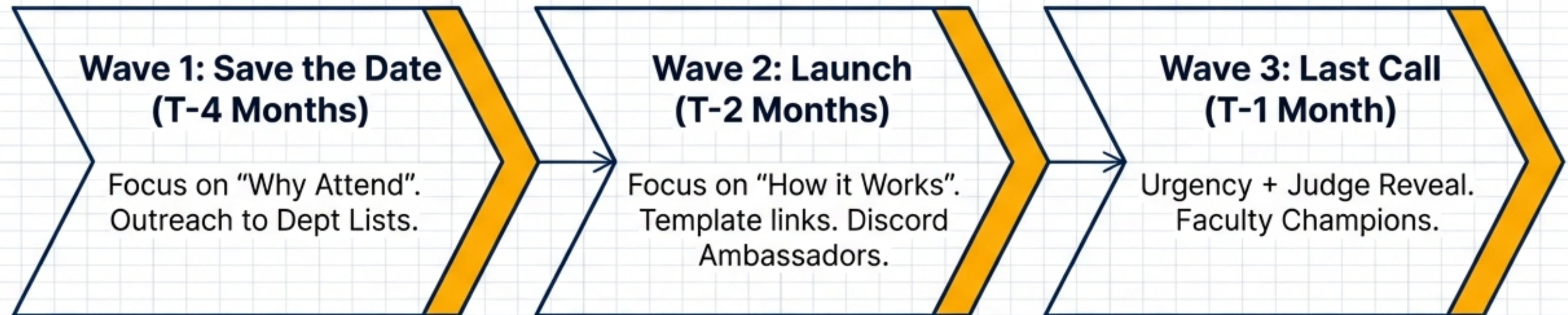


Budget Philosophy

Since venue costs are zero, 100% of funding goes directly to students or prizes.

Marketing & Engagement Strategy

The Hook: "Turn 2 weeks into a seed grant and new collaborators."



Inclusion Tactics

Discipline-specific messaging to prevent self-exclusion (e.g., "Theoretical conjecture welcome", "Wet-lab roadmaps welcome").

Post-Event Impact: The Grant Acceleration Clinic



Long-term Value: Creates a backlog of vetted proposals for departments to cultivate.

Roadmap & Next Steps

Roadmap

- **T-4 Months:** Define spine, secure approval.
- **T-3 Months:** Recruit leadership, lock rubric.
- **T-2 Months:** Open Registration, Tech Rehearsals.
- **T-1 Month:** Team formation social.
- **T+3 Months:** Close loop, sponsor impact report.

Immediate Call to Action

- ✓ 1. Approve the concept.
- ✓ 2. Select the funding tier.
- ✓ 3. Authorize the date hold.

Ready to Launch.